

1. The Question is Not Why Unity Persisted, But Why It Was Rebuilt

Today, I believe I have obtained the answer to a crucial question—one that has puzzled countless scholars: why has China been able to maintain national unity over a relatively long historical period? Here, "unity" refers to the concept of a cultural community or cultural sphere. Naturally, this also requires us to consider the sheer territorial size and historical length of the state itself. Our country's history textbooks and official historiography never shy away from this point; they heavily propagandize it as a symbol of China's superiority, a matter worthy of national pride.

However, our country's historical narratives are saturated with teleology (先定论) and myths. For example, during compulsory education history classes, when teachers arrive at a certain historical fact in chronological order, they require students to memorize the impacts and significance of this event, simply because these will become testing points in exams. But from a research perspective, whether it is the impact of a historical event or the evaluation of a historical figure's achievements, it must inevitably be post-determined (后定的)—only time can reveal the true caliber of an endeavor.

More severely, official historiography is highly inclined to attribute China's unity to the civil and military statecraft of Emperor Qin Shi Huang, Ying Zheng (秦始皇帝嬴政), in initially unifying and pacifying the realm—namely, treating the pacification of the Six States, the establishment of the emperor system, and the standardization of weights and measures (度量衡), writing, currency, etc., as the historical roots of our country's long-term unity. But obviously, this view is extremely unconvincing. First, some of these measures essentially played no role at all; second, some measures were significant but not necessarily strongly correlated with political unity; third, looking globally, many rulers outside of China adopted similar measures at different times, yet clearly, no other country followed the same developmental trajectory as China; finally, the rapid collapse and demise of the Qin Dynasty following its unification serves as rather direct proof of its governance failure.

A highly typical example is the so-called standardization of weights and measures. In Chinese, the three characters *du* (度), *liang* (量), and *heng* (衡) measure an object's length, volume, and mass, respectively. However, at the political level, these three units of measurement can hardly be treated as equals. The unit of mass is extremely closely tied to trade; it not only provides the precise weight of goods but is also required to calibrate the value of precious metal currencies—which, even in ancient societies, were widely recognized across the world as functioning as general equivalents (一般等价物). The scope of such trade far exceeded the borders of any single state, thereby allowing the use of mass units and currency forms to easily cross political boundaries.

A unit like the ounce, even after the collapse of Rome when most of Europe was never again under a single regime for long, continued to be commonly used by many European countries. The carat, currently the unit for measuring the mass of gemstones, was originally nothing more than the mass of a plant seed, yet it came to be commonly used by numerous nations across Eurasia and Africa with different ethnicities, religious beliefs, and even those actively at war with one another. Such situations also existed in the pre-feudal period. For example, the Talent (塔兰同), a unit of mass used in the ancient Near East and the Greco-Roman world, was utilized across the borders of empires. Currencies are the same: the coins of the Byzantine Empire were accepted in the Persian region, and

the copper coins of the Song Dynasty were highly popular in Japan. This was the result of economic interests and market forces, not something dictated by political coercion.

On the eve of the Qin dynasty's unification, an obvious fact is that a nationwide market had already formed. Otherwise, the *Warring States period* (战国时期) would not have seen the emergence of world-renowned commercial hubs like Dingtao (定陶), as well as a large number of immensely wealthy merchants—even grand merchants like Lü Buwei (吕不韦), whose entry into politics allowed him to profoundly influence the political trajectory.

It is precisely based on this fact, supported by historical examples outside of China, that I believe there is absolutely no reason to assume that even if China had not achieved political unification, the various kingdoms that had reached a balance of power would not have shared common mass units and currency forms. Conversely, could these elements, which were capable of unifying spontaneously due to commercial factors, truly and firmly sustain political unification? Obviously, they could not. Even if European nations adopted the same weight units and currencies, it could not prevent them from going to war with one another. For Christians and Muslims in border regions, they might have used the exact same currency and weighing standards, but this could not guarantee they would perpetually shake hands in peace.

In short, a unified market does not equate to a politically unified state. Furthermore, we can discover that written script is the exact same case. The unified Roman Empire used Latin, and subsequently, the Catholic Church also used Latin. The problem is that even though Latin was the official and universal written language of the Catholic states of Europe during the Middle Ages, no single state was ever seen recreating the Romans' grand achievement. In fact, starting from the late Middle Ages, the status of Latin gradually declined, while the vernacular scripts of various peoples rose in tandem with the sprouting of nation-states.

A concept that stands in stark contrast to this involves units of length and volume (capacity). The latter is largely calibrated by the former, because volume is fundamentally the cube of length. These two concepts are highly bound to politics. This is because taxation—as one of the fundamental functions of the state apparatus—must be measured using length and volume. The former determines the area of land, while the latter measures the quantity of grain.

The consequence of this binding is that the use of length units is intimately connected to political borders. Before the global adoption of the metric system, Russia had the verst (俄里), Britain had the mile (英里), Japan had the Japanese ri (日本里), and China had the Chinese li (中国里); even different regions within the same country had different length standards. Before Italy's unification in 1870, there were almost as many length standards as there were states. Medieval monarchs even used the length between the joints of their own bodies to establish a standard.

Whether political power is strong or weak determines how wide a scope the length standard established by that regime will be utilized. In late medieval Japan, the regimes of Oda Nobunaga (织田信长) and Toyotomi Hideyoshi (丰臣秀吉) both made the Kinki region (近畿地区) their center of rule. Therefore, when the *Azuchi-Momoyama regime* (安土桃山政权) conducted nationwide land surveys (Kenchi 检地), they used the land standards of the Kinki region to measure land throughout the country (which, of course, also included the *shō* [升], a unit of volume).

However, a highly notable issue is that Chinese historical records do not actually believe that the "measure of length" (*du* 度) was unified during the reign of Qin Shi Huang. The *Yantie Lun* (Discourses on Salt and Iron / 盐铁论), authored by Huan Kuan (桓宽) in the Western Han Dynasty, cites the argument of the "Ministers of Profit" (兴利之臣)—the faction of the Censor-in-Chief (*Yushi Daifu* 御史大夫), Sang Hongyang (桑弘羊). It points out that, in reality, it was during the reign of Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝)—the longest-reigning monarch of the Han Dynasty—that China finally achieved the unification of length (*du*). This emperor unified the *mu* (亩, a unit of land area) system across the *Guandong* (关东) and *Guanxi* (关西) regions, enabling all the land under heaven to be measured by a single standard. Furthermore, this argument was not questioned by the "Worthies and Literati" (*Xianliang Wenxue* 贤良文学) faction during the debate.

Equally, a crucial enterprise finally completed during the reign of Emperor Wu of Han was the currency reform. In fact, the term "currency reform" is highly deceptive and misleading. From the perspective of the market and economic laws, the form of currency itself can reach a consensus without the need for political coercion—though political measures can, of course, accelerate this process. When we speak of the Han Dynasty's currency reform today, to a large extent, we are not referring to the final establishment of the *Wuzhu coin* (五铢钱) as the standard currency form. Rather, we are referring to the fact that the right of coinage (铸币权) was completely withdrawn from the localities and centralized in the hands of the central government. This was achieved when state power surged to its absolute zenith during the **classical period** (古典时期). In contrast, during the Qin Dynasty, the failure of grassroots governance meant that the Qin Empire could not possibly stop the illicit minting of private currency; thus, this matter had to be dragged out for a century until it was resolved by Liu Che (刘彻).

Considering a more extreme scenario: so what if two or more currencies circulate within a single country? Japan during the early and mid-Edo period (江户中前期) serves as an excellent example. The fact is that, even without the coercive regulatory measures of the Chinese Empire, Japan during the Edo period still experienced what could be called miraculous economic progress, and the national unity of Japan was similarly consolidated during its **early modern period** (近世). Given this, exactly how many of the measures taken by Ying Zheng—this so-called "emperor of the millennia"—were truly beneficial to Chinese society, and how many were merely driven by the despotic and arrogant ambitions of an autocratic ruler?

The doubts raised above not only point out that it is extremely absurd to believe that a few top-down measures adopted by Qin Shi Huang—under circumstances where there was absolutely no administrative power to enforce them, and fundamentally no adequate time to popularize them—somehow laid the foundation for long-term unity. Moreover, these doubts quickly redirect the issue toward a new direction. For example, as we mentioned earlier regarding the unification of script: the Roman Empire used Latin, and the Catholic Church used Latin. Then, why did vernacular languages begin to rise across Europe during the late Middle Ages, causing Latin to eventually become a "language of the museum"? (Here, I ask readers to note the specific context brought about by the place where I live: in mainland China, when people speak of "Latin," they are referring specifically to the language with a unified written script used by the Roman Empire and the Catholic Church—one of the "universal languages of the four corners" of a classical empire—while French, Spanish, and Italian are not called Latin).

This line of thought is of utmost importance. It actually pinpoints a fatal flaw in official historiography: the problem of China's unity is absolutely not a question of why it was completed, but rather a question of why it was rebuilt after being interrupted. We will immediately see the astonishing results this line of thought brings.

Since teleology (先定论) presents so many problems, how then do we "post-determine" (后定地) the answer to this question? I believe the key might lie in comparative historical sociology (比较历史学). We must utilize stage-by-stage comparisons to finally determine at which historical moment the divergence between China and the rest of the world occurred.

If we compare the ancient civilization of China with other civilizations on the Eurasian continent and even the New World, their beginnings were similar. Following the agricultural revolution, settlements first emerged in regions with relatively advanced production, subsequently forming cultures that radiated across certain areas. During the Neolithic Age, class stratification appeared, followed by early city-states. Although the cultural radiation of early city-states could be highly extensive—with artifacts bearing their cultural characteristics being unearthed in distant lands—their actual political influence was exceedingly limited. This was true not only in relation to humans but also to nature. Early city-states were often established in geographically advantageous natural locations; however, underdeveloped productive forces left humans lacking the capacity to transform their surrounding environment. Therefore, they were much like isolated islands in the wilderness.

Once evident climate or geological disasters occurred, these one or two isolated islands could easily be "submerged," and the local inhabitants would have no choice but to face the prospect of crossing an unknown "ocean" to try and find the next "island." Hence, in early human societies—regardless of where on the Eurasian continent—archaeologists are constantly faced with a specific set of questions: Why was this early city abandoned? Why did this culture disappear in such a short time? Why do we not know the whereabouts of the ancestors of this culture?

This precisely reflects the characteristics of that era: people lacked the ability to "reclaim land from the sea" beyond their isolated islands. Once this island could no longer sustain life, the inhabitants simply could not guarantee they would survive to reach the next "island of civilization." They were highly likely to perish; and if they detached themselves from relatively developed agricultural regions, their society would undergo regression, to the point of losing their original cultural characteristics. The early regimes of the Xia (夏) and Shang (商) dynasties were constrained by such low productive forces. The frequent relocations of the capital during the early and middle Shang Dynasty were highly likely caused by these low productive forces; agricultural farming methods were far too crude, making it necessary to seek a new ruling center after a certain period to allow the original land to restore its fertility. Along with the advancement of production, politics began to stabilize during the middle and late Shang Dynasty, and the craftsmanship of bronze wares experienced a massive leap forward.

By the Zhou Dynasty (周代), social productive forces in the Central Plains (Zhongyuan / 中原) had risen to such a level that people had mastered a certain degree of methods for transforming nature. They could open up new base areas of civilization in wildernesses where civilization previously could not set foot. This was much like creating a new island through land reclamation in the sea beyond the original isolated islands. The rule of the Zhou Dynasty adapted to this new situation. According to the patriarchal clan system (Zongfa 制度) based on bloodlines, the Zhou rulers dispatched their relatives and meritorious officials, providing them with certain initial assistance,

and sent them to distant eastern lands to establish states. This was a system of "colonization," while the most critical locations—such as vital transportation routes and regions rich in metal deposits—were entrusted to their own relatives.

This grand expansion brought about by the advancement of productive forces did not occur solely in China. In Greece, after the end of the Dark Ages, the Greeks and Phoenicians established a vast number of new colonies and city-states across the Mediterranean; city-states like Carthage even developed into great powers in later days. The environment of the Iranian Plateau was also gradually transformed. Civilization broke out of Mesopotamia and Elam, and new regimes were established in the hinterland of the plateau, eventually growing into a pivotal empire in later times. The Aryans (this term is too archaic; it seems more appropriate to say populations speaking Indo-European languages) moved eastward, first entering the Indus Valley, and subsequently gradually completing the conquest of Northern India during the final millennium BCE.

During this period, Chinese history did not exhibit characteristics distinct enough to differentiate it from other parts of the world. As the colonial expansion of the final stage before the common era reached its zenith, a series of unprecedentedly colossal classical empires emerged. These included the First Persian Empire through the Second Persian Empire (with the Sassanid Dynasty serving as the typical classical empire), the Macedonian Empire and its successors, the Roman Empire, the Maurya Empire, and the Gupta Empire (with India featuring the Gupta Empire as its typical classical period), as well as the Qin and Han Empires. If we solely consider the stages of historical development and broaden the time constraints, the Khmer Empire (高棉帝国) is undoubtedly one of them as well.

These empires shared many commonalities, including: unprecedentedly vast territories, expanded monarchical authority, strengthened administrative power, highly developed commodity economies, high urbanization rates, and bureaucratic systems that were more perfected than ever before. These regimes frequently adopted measures similar to those of the Qin Empire: the unification of various measurement standards and the establishment of official written scripts. Although this fact is not difficult to understand, within the academic environment of our country, it is truly not universally known. There is no doubt that the Qin and Han Empires were part of a normal historical current (specific explanations will follow later). Therefore, an observer must continue looking further down the timeline.

Within at most ten centuries, all classical empires disintegrated; not a single one could escape this fate. Moreover, this disintegration also possessed a high degree of similarity: political collapse, chaotic wars among warlords, the shrinking of the commodity economy, and severe urban decay. The most fascinating characteristics are two-fold: first, the large-scale migration of ethnic minorities and their penetration into the core regions of civilization; second, following the decline of the commodity economy, self-sufficient production units increasingly formed at the local level, a phenomenon often regarded outside of China as the beginning of **feudalization** (封建化).

The most typical examples in this historical process were Rome and China. Positioned respectively at the western and eastern ends of the Eurasian wave of human migration, chaotic warlord divisions and the inward migration of ethnic minorities shattered these two empires. In China, as **feudalization** unfolded, a number of aristocratic clans (Shizu / 士族) possessing massive agricultural estates emerged, evolving into powerful elite lineages (Menfa / 门阀) during the empire's disintegration and wielding formidable influence in state politics.

Similarly, the Khmer Empire, as the last classical empire in human history—even if delayed by a millennium—experienced the exact same fate. The ethnic migrations in the Indochinese Peninsula originated from southwestern China; starting from the Tang Dynasty, the continuous southward push of the Thai and Burmese peoples destroyed the great empires of the Indochinese Peninsula, just as the *Five Barbarians* (五胡) and the various Germanic peoples of Europe had done previously.

In the central part of the Eurasian continent, the Persian region began to suffer increasingly frequent incursions by nomadic tribes. However, unfortunately, due to its overly central geographical position, the agony of barbarian invasions could obviously not be concluded after just one or two occurrences, unlike in other countries around the world. Even in the South Asian subcontinent, invasions by nomadic peoples posed massive threats over a certain period. Six centuries later, Turkic Muslims (this description is indeed the popular understanding among the Chinese; after all, it is difficult for people in China to distinguish between Turks and Persians. Accurately speaking, they should be described as conquerors with a mixed Turco-Persian cultural background) kicked open the doors to India, turning this threat into a reality.

That is to say, up until this point, the historical process of China had still not presented a decisive divergence from the rest of the world. However, in the subsequent period, this divergence clearly occurred. (The situations of Byzantium, Iran, and the Arabs were relatively unique and will be discussed later).

Three centuries after the collapse of the Roman Empire, the various Germanic peoples who had successfully invaded the Western Empire began to establish new regimes locally, embraced Christianity, and laid the foundation for the European **feudal system**. This was an outcome of universal significance. Disregarding the complex spatiotemporal processes in between, new empires did not emerge from the ruins of classical empires; instead, those former barbarians ultimately evolved into a multitude of nation-states after undergoing **feudalization** (封建化). We can now easily name a string of such countries, including France, Germany, Italy, Thailand, Myanmar, Laos, and even Turkey.

The only somewhat different case is India. However, we must point out that India's current unity is largely owed to the British. Between the Maurya Empire and India's independence, a unified India ruled by Indians and adhering to Indian religions was long unimaginable. Even when the South Asian subcontinent was largely integrated under a single regime, it was the work of Turks and Mongols, with the Indians as the ruled.

Only in China, less than three centuries after the fall of the Western Jin Dynasty (西晋), did the Sui and Tang empires reunify the state. Furthermore, with the reunification of the empire, the forces of division weakened increasingly over time, while political unity grew ever more consolidated. By the late imperial period of the Ming and Qing dynasties, a scenario of fragmentation like that of the *Three Kingdoms*, *Northern and Southern Dynasties*, or *Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms* (三国南北朝五代十国) had become unimaginable.

At this point, a fundamental divergence surfaces. In making the above deduction, we actually adopted a method similar to an electrician troubleshooting a circuit: first, a voltage tester (测电笔) reveals no problem at the first node; the second node still has no problem. But when the current or voltage is abnormal at the third node, we can assert that a fault has occurred in the circuit between the second and third nodes. What must be done now is to trace backward from the third node to find

exactly where the problem lies. Although circuit troubleshooting and historiography appear completely different, I sense that the scientific spirit within them is identical, and their methodologies are highly likely interconnected. Since this decisive difference occurred at the turn of the 6th and 7th centuries CE, we must consider the following conclusion: on the eve of reunification, Chinese society had evidently already developed a fundamental divergence compared to the rest of the world, especially Europe. Where exactly did this divergence lie?

Once the deduction reached this step, no progress was made for nearly two years. However, last week, while casually scrolling through short videos on my phone, I suddenly came across a concept I had seen countless times before: the Five Surnames and Seven Prominent Families (*Wuxing Qiwang* / 五姓七望). During the Sui and Tang dynasties, this term referred to several of the most powerful and prestigious grand families in Northern China. I had seen this concept so many times before without feeling anything in particular, but this time, it suddenly struck me: on the eve of China's reunification, there were the Five Surnames and Seven Prominent Families among the northern aristocratic clans (*Shizu* / 士族); meanwhile, the aristocratic clans that had migrated south during the Six Dynasties of Jiangzuo (江左六朝), along with the local aristocratic clans that arose in the south, clearly had not completely vanished either, despite suffering massive blows during the Hou Jing Rebellion (侯景之乱). For instance, the Lanling Xiao clan (兰陵萧氏) still exerted considerable influence during the Sui and Tang periods.

This fact implies that, following a three-century historical process of inward migration and large-scale invasions by ethnic minorities since the Wei and Jin dynasties—although we cannot obtain specific proportional statistics today—agricultural real estate in China remained largely in the hands of the Han people, especially Han *landlords* (汉族地主). Land ownership had not undergone significant changes. This point in itself is extremely bizarre, as it clearly contradicts what happened in the rest of the world.

When backward peoples still in a state of clan-based tribalism lingered on the fringes of the civilized world, their productive and cultural levels would rapidly elevate through learning from advanced peoples (often the empire). Within a relatively short period, they would develop to the point where they urgently needed more land to establish relations of production (生产关系) fitting their current situation—namely, socio-economic relations under a **feudal system**.

The answer to this question is obvious. When the Germanic peoples entered the Western Empire, they inevitably and ultimately had to turn the Romans' land into their own, with tribal leaders and subordinate chieftains of various ranks becoming the future emperors, kings, dukes, and marquises. When the Turks moved from east to west and finally began encroaching upon the Eastern Empire's Asian territories, they also inevitably established a Turkish **feudal system** in Asia Minor, which culminated in the formation of the nation-state of Turkey today.

On a global scale, the most typical example of conquerors seizing the territory of the conquered and transforming their own elites into **feudal lords** of various ranks over the newly acquired land is the Norman Conquest (诺曼征服) in the 11th century. Ten thousand Normans conquered England, which had a population of 1.5 million Anglo-Saxons (盎格鲁-撒克逊人). William the Conqueror (征服者威廉) mercilessly confiscated the land of the Anglo-Saxon nobility nationwide and enfeoffed it to the Norman nobles who had followed him from France, according to feudal relations. Consequently, across England as a whole, land ownership was transferred into the hands of the Norman

conquerors. (Regarding the concept of land ownership during the feudal period, I have provided an explanation in Section 30 of Chapter 12; those with questions may refer to it.)

Before his death, William I conducted another nationwide land survey—similar to what the Japanese refer to as *Kenchí* (检地)—and compiled the *Domesday Book* (《温彻斯特书》 / 《末日审判书》), supplemented by oath-taking assemblies, which ultimately massively strengthened the **feudal system** in England. The brilliance of referencing the Norman Conquest is that it provides a typical outcome of **feudalization**, revealing the following fact: depriving the conquered of their land and enfeoffing it to the major and minor rulers among the conquerors according to feudal political relations is something that barbarians—possessing the need for **feudalization**—must do in order to adjust to *the relations of production* (生产关系) suited to their productive forces.

A massive question thus arises: since the behaviors of the Germanic peoples, Normans, Turks, Burmese, and Thai all followed this law, why did the *Five Barbarians* (五胡) active in Northern China fail to do so? Something unnoticed must have occurred here.

This doubt is immediately linked to another fascinating issue in Chinese history: the so-called question of "*Sinicization*" (汉化). Why is it that ethnic minorities from the north conquered the entirety of China twice, and conquered Northern China even more frequently, yet their cultures and lifestyles ultimately became almost completely Sinicized, leaving behind only minimal traces? Our official historiography similarly loves to propagandize this point, treating it as a symbol of the formidable power of Chinese culture.

However, simple mathematical deductions indicate that the reason is absolutely not as simple as it appears. Take William's conquest of England, for instance: he brought slightly over ten thousand Normans. When the national land survey concluded twenty years later, England had a population of 1.5 million. Considering his forceful purges of England, the number of Anglo-Saxons prior to the conquest was likely even higher. This means that William utilized less than 1% of the conquered population's manpower to accomplish the monumental task of consolidating the **feudal system** in the conquered territory.

In contrast, during the period when the inward migration of northern ethnic minorities into China reached its absolute peak—namely, the 4th and 5th centuries CE—even after prolonged and brutal wars, the Han Chinese population in Northern China still constituted the majority. However, the ratio of Barbarians to Han could absolutely not have been as low as 1%. Because even considering the population of a single ethnicity like the *Xianbei* (鲜卑), it numbered at least in the millions. The *Xiongnu* (匈奴) and *Qiang* (羌) had migrated inward long ago and lived intermingled with the Han for an extended period; their populations might have also been in the millions. In this light, even a conservative estimate would place the population of ethnic minorities (excluding the Han) in the northern regions at between 5 million and 10 million. Meanwhile, the Han population could absolutely not have reached the nine-digit mark (100 million)—an order of magnitude that was not achieved until the Song Dynasty.

From another perspective, the armed forces of the ethnic minorities during the Sixteen Kingdoms and the *Northern and Southern Dynasties* (十六国南北朝) were already highly advanced.

Cataphracts (具装骑兵) became extremely common in Northern China. In fact, the technological gap between the Barbarians and the Han had already drastically narrowed; we can even argue that no generational gap (代差) in military technology existed between them.

Therefore, we can make the following assertion: for the ethnic minority conquerors sweeping across the north, it was by no means an impossible task—in terms of the balance of power—to feudalize Northern China and completely control it with their own tribesmen, just like their counterparts in other parts of the world. Since this is the case, why didn't the minority rulers in the north accomplish this?

A crucial line of thought perhaps lies in Karl Marx's proposition that "labor creates culture" (although not originally coined by him, Marx placed it at the core of his theory). Labor implies not only a specific mode of production and way of life, but also that laborers participate in a broad spectrum of social relations.

This proposition can be used to explain some fascinating topics. For instance, why do Jewish people always appear in the perceptions of other nations as the stereotype of merchants and bankers? Marx's viewpoint perfectly resolves this issue. It is absolutely not that Jewish people are significantly smarter than other nations, nor are they innately more adept at commerce and finance. Rather, because the Jewish people lost their state and wandered the world since before the Common Era, they always constituted a small minority within local communities and were politically disadvantaged. This resulted in a situation where, once a Jewish person actively participated in physical labor—for instance, becoming a farmer or a craftsman—he would become German in Germany, Russian in Russia, or British in Britain. It was precisely by engaging in non-productive professions (脱产的工作), occupying a marginal position in the social structure, and living within closed communities to perform jobs like money-lending, that a segment of the Jewish population was able to preserve their religion and culture.

Therefore, we can say it is not that Jewish people are inherently skilled at commerce and finance, but rather that only those who chose this profession in the past are still recognized as Jewish today, while the other Jewish people who labored directly using the means of production (生产资料) were assimilated locally. There are many such examples. The Armenians (亚美尼亚人), after the fall of their nation, also went into exile along the Silk Road; their perceived image is similarly one of adeptness in trade. The Chinese have intermittently migrated to Southeast Asia since the Song Dynasty; the image of ethnic Chinese among the indigenous peoples of Southeast Asia is practically identical to that of Jewish people in Europe—seen as shrewd, cunning, and even exacting. Again, this is not because Armenians and Chinese are genuinely just that clever, cunning, and adept at commerce, but simply because only such people could retain their original ethnic and cultural characteristics, while the other immigrants gradually became indistinguishable from the natives.

India's Jainism (耆那教) is even more fascinating. Theologically, it possessed no way to compete among the masses against Buddhism and Hinduism, both born in India. However, the restrictions imposed by its doctrines ensured that its followers would not engage in agriculture or slaughtering, and thus the majority engaged in commerce and trade. This non-productive (脱产) lifestyle paradoxically guaranteed their detached status, allowing its followers—though appearing few within India's massive population—to consistently pass down their traditions.

The brilliance of Marx's viewpoint is that he utilizes a scientific theory to explain ethnic issues, rather than attributing them to some mystical, unverifiable "national character" (民族性). The prominent social status achieved by Jewish people globally today actually benefits from the fact that they secured an advantage in commerce and finance during the late Middle Ages, prior to the **early modern period**. Two subsequent historical facts then provided them with the opportunity to

skyrocket. First, the outcome of early modernization ultimately rendered capital (资本) the most critical *factor of production* (生产要素); thus, the Jewish people, having seized the early initiative, naturally enjoyed the advantage of being close to the source. Second, Europe achieved overwhelming dominance over the rest of the world during the process of modernization, allowing the Jewish people to ride this wave to the very top. Although this seemingly legendary process might have originally stemmed from Christian doctrines (such as the prohibition on usury)—which forced the Jewish people, as undesirables, to fill an indispensable "ecological niche" (生态位) to invigorate the social economy in the late Middle Ages—the rise of the Jewish people can indeed be explained by social science theories without resorting to theology.

Applying the same law in the opposite direction, we arrive at another fact: a nation occupying an advantageous position can expand its culture by controlling social production. England serves as a typical example here once again. Although the Normans constituted only a minuscule fraction of England's total population after the initial conquest, they genuinely seized control of the primary means of production in English society, especially land. It was precisely because they dominated social production that the Normans were able to impose their culture onto Anglo-Saxon English society with irresistible force. The immense influence that modern English received from French is absolutely incomparable to the impact any ethnic minority language had on Chinese after passing through the gates, including the Manchu language (满语).

In reality, not a single feudalized barbarian regime failed to firmly root its own culture into the newly conquered lands. A traveler visiting Germany in the 12th century could not possibly believe he was still in the ancient Roman Empire; a traveler visiting Turkey in the 17th century could not believe he was still in the Eastern Roman Empire; a traveler visiting eastern Thailand in the 18th century could not believe he was still in the Khmer Empire. It is precisely through the redistribution of land—whereby conquerors firmly grasp land ownership and subsequently directly control and participate in social production—that the old culture can be swept away on a massive scale, thereby firmly consolidating their own rule. It is labor that creates new culture, and it is the dominance over social production that asserts and expands such new culture.

Therefore, without a doubt, we have now actually found the answer to the so-called question of "*Sinicization*" (汉化). The reason why the ethnic minorities that conquered China always seemed to vanish—like a bag of salt dissolving into a large pond—is absolutely not because Han culture possessed some magical, supernatural power. The fundamental reason lies in the fact that they abandoned **feudalization** (封建化). They did not directly control the land, nor did they directly participate in social production—which, of course, prior to the Industrial Revolution, primarily meant agricultural production. But if they did not undergo **feudalization**, then what exactly did the minority rulers do? The answer is: *Bureaucratization* (官僚化).

1, 问题不在于统一为何持续, 在于统一为何重建

在今天, 我想我得到了一个重要问题的答案, 这个问题不知曾困扰了多少学者, 那就是为什么中国能够在历史上维持较长期期的国家统一, 这里的“统一”是针对文化共同体或文化圈这样的概念而言的。当然, 这也要求我们考虑的国家本身具有一定的幅员大小和历史长度。我们国家的历史教科书和官方史学从不避讳这一点, 并且将其视为中国优越性的一个象征而大肆宣传, 是一件值得国民感到自豪的事情。然而, 我们国家的历史叙述中充满了先定论和神话, 例如, 在义务教育阶段的历史教学中, 老师们按时间顺序讲到某一个史实, 就会要求学生背诵这件事情产生的影响和意义, 因为这些都会成为考试中的考点。但是从研究的角度考虑, 不管是一个历史事件产生的影响, 还是对一个历史人物功业的评价, 都必

然是后定的，只有时间才能显现事业的成色。更为严重的是，官方史学非常倾向于把中国的统一归功于秦始皇嬴政初一泰平的文治武功，也就是将削平六国、建立皇帝制度、统一度量衡，文字，货币等等视为我国长期统一的历史根源。但显然这种观点极难令人信服。首先，这些措施中的一些根本就没有起到什么作用；其次，一些措施具有意义但是未见得与政治统一有强关联；其三，在世界范围内看，中国以外的许多统治者在不同的时间也采取过类似的措施，但是显然除了中国以外的每个国家都没有和中国相同的发展路径；最后，秦朝统一之后的迅速败亡也相当直接地证明了其治理失败。

一个非常典型的例子就是所谓统一度量衡，“度、量、衡”三个汉字在中文里分别衡量了物体的长度，容积和质量，然而这三种计量单位在政治层面却难以等量齐观。质量单位跟贸易有着极为密切的联系，它不仅给出了货物的精确重量，更需要被用来标定在古代社会就已经在世界各地被广泛承认具有一般等价物功能的贵金属货币的价值。这种贸易的范围远远超过了某一个国家的国境线，进而导致质量单位以及货币形制的使用可以轻而易举地跨过政治边界。像盎司这样的单位，即使在罗马崩溃之后欧洲大部分地区再也没有长久处于一个政权治下，它仍然被欧洲许多国家所共同使用。现在衡量宝石质量的单位克拉，最早不过是一种植物种子的质量，却被欧亚非许许多多不同种族，不同宗教信仰，甚至相互敌对交战的国家所共同使用。这样的情况前封建时期也存在，例如塔兰同（Talent）这一古代近东和希腊罗马世界使用的质量单位，它被使用的范围跨过了帝国之间的边界。货币也是一样的例子，东罗马帝国的货币在波斯地区也被接受，宋朝的铜钱在日本广受欢迎，这是经济利益和市场推动的结果，而不是政治强力所决定的。

在秦朝统一前夕，一个显而易见的事实是全国范围内的市场已经形成了，不然战国时期便不会出现像定陶这样天下闻名的商业重镇，以及一大批富可敌国，乃至像吕不韦这样在从政后足以深刻影响政治走向的大商人。正是基于这一事实，以及中国以外的历史实例的支撑，我相信没有任何理由认为即使中国不在政治上实现统一，各个达到势力均衡的王国就不会拥有共同的质量单位和货币形制。反过来说，这些因为商业因素就能够自发统一的因素，真的能够牢靠地将统一维持下去吗？显然也做不到，欧洲国家之间即使采取相同的计重单位和货币，也不能阻止他们之间彼此交战。对于交界地区的基督徒和穆斯林来说，他们或许用着一样的货币采取一样的称重标准，也不能保证双方一直握手言和。一言以蔽之，统一的市场不等于政治统一的国家。进而我们可以发现文字也是一样的例子，一个统一的罗马帝国使用拉丁文，紧接着天主教会也使用拉丁文，问题在于，即使拉丁文在中世纪是天主教欧洲各国的官方文字，通用文字，也从未见有哪个国家能够重现罗马人的伟业，甚至于从中世纪末期开始，拉丁文的地位逐渐下降，反而是各民族的文字随着民族国家的萌发崛起了。

而与之相对比鲜明的概念就是长度和容积单位，后者在很大程度上被前者所标定，因为体积本来就是长度的立方。这两个概念与政治高度绑定，这是因为税收作为国家机器的基本功能之一，必须要用长度和容积进行丈量，前者确定了土地的面积，而后者则衡量了谷物的多少。这种绑定带来的后果是，长度单位的使用与政治边界息息相关，在全世界普遍采取公制之前，俄国有俄里，英国有英里，在日本有日本里，在中国有中国里，同一个国家不同地区的长度标准也不一样。意大利在1870年统一之前，几乎是有多少国家，就有多少个长度标准。中世纪的君主甚至用自己的身体上关节之间的长度来确定一个标准。政治权力的强势与否决定了这个政权所制定的长度标准将使用多大的范围，在日本中世晚期，织田信长和丰臣秀吉的政权都将近畿地区作为自己的统治中心，因此安土桃山政权在全国范围内进行检地的时候，就以近畿地区的土地标准来丈量全国各地的土地（当然也包括升这一体积单位）。然而，一个非常值得注意的问题是，中国的历史记载并不认为是秦始皇时期就统一了“度”，西汉桓宽所著的《盐铁论》里引用了御史大夫桑弘羊一方的“兴利之臣”的论据。它指出，实际上是在汉朝在位最长的君主，汉武帝时期中国才最终实现了“度”的统一，这个皇帝统一了关东和关西地区的亩制，使得天下的土地都得以用一种标准进行丈量。这个论据在辩论中也并未被贤良文学一方所质疑。

同样在汉武帝时期最终完成的一个关键事业是币制改革，事实上，币制改革的这个称谓具有极大的迷惑性和误导性，站在市场和经济规律的角度，货币的形制本身是不需要政治强力就能够达成一种一致的，当然政治举措会加快这个过程。今天我们说的汉代币制改革，很大程度上不是说到最后以五铢钱作为标准货币的形制，而是指铸币权从地方完全收归中央，这是国家力量在古典时期增强到顶峰这个阶段所实现的。而在秦代，基层治理的失效使得秦帝国根本不可能制止私铸货币，因而这件事情就只能拖到一个世纪之后才被刘彻所解决。考虑更极端的情况，就算有两种或者以上的货币在一个国家中出现又能怎么样呢？江户中前期的日本就是个很好的例子，事实就是即使没有像中华帝国这样强制性的规范措施，

江户时期依然发生了可以称为奇迹的经济进步，日本的国家统一在近世一样是得到巩固了。既然如此，那么嬴政这个所谓的千古一帝到底有多少举措是真正有益于中国社会的，而有多少是仅仅出于一个专制统治者专横狂妄的野心？以上质疑不仅指出了认为仅仅靠秦始皇帝所采取的一些自上而下的措施，在根本没有行政力量保证的情况下，在根本没有足够的时间去推广的情况下，就奠定了所谓长期统一的基础是极为荒谬的事情。不仅如此，这些质疑，很快将问题引向了一个新的方向，例如我们之前在统一文字时所说的，罗马帝国使用拉丁文，天主教会使用拉丁文，那么，为什么到中世纪晚期民族的语言开始在欧洲各地崛起，以至于使拉丁文（这里请读到的人注意我个人所生活的地方所带来的特殊语境，在中国大陆，人们说到拉丁文的时候指的就是罗马帝国以及天主教会所使用的具有统一书写方式的语言，是古典帝国“四方通语”中的一种，而法语，西班牙语和意大利语并不被叫做拉丁文）成为了一种“博物馆中的语言”？这个思路至关重要，他实际上指出了官方史学中非常要命的一点，中国的统一问题绝不是它为什么完成统一的问题，而是统一在中断之后为什么被重建的问题。我们马上就会看到这种思路所带来的惊人结果。

既然先定论具有如此多的问题，那么我们如何“后定地”确定这个问题的答案呢？我认为关键或许是比较历史学，我们必须通过分阶段的比较来最终确定中国与世界其他地方的差异出现在哪个历史时刻。如果把中国的古代文明同欧亚大陆乃至新大陆的其他文明相对比，它们的开始是相似的，农业革命之后，一些生产相对先进的地方先产生了聚落，接着形成了辐射一定范围的文化。在新石器时代，阶级分化出现，随之而来的是早期城邦国家。早期城邦国家虽然文化辐射可以很广泛，在遥远的地方也会出土具有该文化特征的文物，但实际的政治影响力非常有限。这不仅仅是对人而言，而且是对自然而言，早期城邦往往在自然位置优越的地理位置建立，但是落后的生产力使得人类缺乏对周边环境进行改造的能力，因此它们很像荒野中的孤岛。一旦气候或者地质发生明显的灾害，这一两个孤岛就很容易被“淹没”，而当地居民就不得不面临着穿过未知的“大海”去试图寻找下一个“岛屿”的境地。因此，在人类社会早期不管是在欧亚大陆的什么地方，考古学家总是面临这么一种问题，为什么这个早期城市被废弃了，为什么这个文化在很短的时间内消失了，为什么这个文化的先民我们不知道他的去向？这恰恰反映了当年的时代特征，人们没有在孤岛之外“填海造陆”的能力，一旦这个岛不能生存，居民们根本没办法保证自己活着到下一个“文明的岛屿”，他们很有可能无法存活，而如果脱离较为发达的农耕地区，则社会又会发生退化，以至于丧失原先的文化特征。夏朝和商朝的早期政权受到了这种低下生产力的制约，商代中前期频繁地迁移其首都，很有可能就是生产力低下所导致的，农业耕作方式太过粗犷，因此必须要在一段时间后寻找新的统治中心来使原有的土地恢复肥力。随着生产进步，商代中后期开始政治变得稳定下来，青铜器的制作水平出现了巨大的飞跃。

到了周代，中原的社会生产力上升到了这么一种地步，人们已经掌握了一定程度的改造自然的办法，可以在原先文明不能涉足的荒野中开辟出文明的新根据地，这就好比在孤岛之外的海域通过填海的方式造出一个新岛。周朝的统治就适应了这种新的局面，依照血缘宗法制度，周朝统治者派出自己的亲戚、功臣，给予他们一定的初始援助，让他们到东方的遥远土地去建立国家，这就是一种“殖民”的制度，而将最重要的位置例如交通要道，金属矿藏丰富的地区交给自己的亲戚。而这种生产力进步所带来的大开拓没有只发生在中国，在希腊，黑暗时代结束之后希腊人和腓尼基人在地中海建立了一大批的新殖民地和新城邦，像迦太基（Carthage）这样的城邦在日后甚至发展成为大国。伊朗高原的环境也逐渐得到了改造，文明冲破了美索不达米亚和埃兰，新的政权在高原腹地建立起来，并在日后成长为一个举足轻重的帝国。雅利安人（这个说法太过古老，似乎改成说印欧语的种群较为合适）向东先是进入了印度河流域，紧接着在公元的最后一个千年里渐渐完成了对北印度的征服。在这个时期，中国的历史并没有展现出足以与其他地方相区别的特征。随着公元前最后一个阶段的殖民开拓达到顶峰，一系列空前庞大的古典帝国产生了，他们包括波斯第一帝国至波斯第二帝国（以萨珊王朝为典型古典帝国），马其顿帝国及其继业者，罗马帝国，孔雀王朝（Maurya）以及笈多王朝（Gupta，印度以笈多帝国为典型古典时期）和秦汉帝国，如果我们仅仅考虑历史发展阶段而将时间限制放宽，那么高棉帝国毫无疑问也是其一。这些帝国具有很多共同点，包括：疆土空前庞大，君主权权威扩大，行政力量增强，商品经济发达，城市化率高，官僚体制比以往更完善等等。这些政权往往采取过与秦帝国相似的措施，各种计量标准的统一，以及确立官方文字。这个事实虽然不是那么难以理解，但是在我国的学术环境中，还真不是人尽皆知的，毫无疑问，秦汉帝国是正常的历史潮流中的一部分（具体的解释后面再说），所以观察者必须继续向后看才行。

在至数十个世纪之后，所有的古典帝国都瓦解了，没有一个能逃脱这样的命运。而且这种瓦解同样具有高度的相似性，政治崩溃，军阀混战，商品经济萎缩，城市严重衰退。而最为有意思的特征是两个，其一是少数民族大范围的迁徙并且进入了文明的核心地区，其二是商品经济衰退之后，地方上越来越形成了自给自足的生产单位，而这在中国以外的地方常常被视为封建化的开始。在这个历史进程中最具有典型性的就是罗马和中国，两者分别位于欧亚民族迁徙浪潮的西端和东端，军阀混战割据和少数民族内迁击垮了这两个帝国。在中国，随着封建化的展开，一些拥有庞大地产的士族出现了，并且在帝国瓦解的过程中演变成为门阀，在国家政治中具有强大的影响力。同样的，高棉帝国作为人类历史上最后一个古典帝国，哪怕晚了一千年之久也经历了相同的命运，中南半岛的民族迁徙来源于中国的西南部，泰人和缅甸人从唐代开始持续性的南下，就像之前的五胡和欧洲的日耳曼各民族一样摧毁了中南半岛的大帝国。而在欧亚大陆的中部，波斯地区开始越来越频繁地受到游牧部落的侵袭，然而不幸的是由于其过于靠中的位置，显然蛮族入侵的痛苦不可能像全世界其他国家一样经历一两次就结束。而即使是在南亚次大陆，游牧民族的入侵也在一段时间内造成了巨大威胁，又过了六个世纪，突厥穆斯林（这个说法的确是中国人的通俗认知，毕竟在中国大家很难区别突厥人和波斯人，准确地说，应当是突厥—波斯混合文化背景的征服者）一脚踹开了印度的大门把这种威胁变成了现实。也就是说，一直到这个时候，中国的历史进程也并没有与世界其他地方呈现出决定性的差异，但是接下来一个时期，这种差异明显地发生了。（拜占庭、伊朗和阿拉伯的情况较为特殊，将在后面论及）

在罗马帝国崩溃之后三个世纪，成功入侵了西帝国地区的日耳曼各民族开始在当地建立新的政权，接纳了基督教，并奠定了欧洲封建制度的基础。而这是一种具有普遍意义的结果，不考虑中间复杂的时空过程，古典帝国的废墟上并没有诞生出新的帝国，反而是那些曾经的蛮族最终在封建化之后演化出了林立的民族国家。我们现在很容易说出一连串这样的国家的名字，包括法国，德国，意大利，泰国，缅甸，老挝乃至土耳其等等。唯一不太相同的地方在印度，但是我们必须指出印度现在的统一很大程度上有英国人的功劳在，在孔雀帝国之后，印度独立之前，一个印度人统治的信仰印度宗教的统一印度长期以来也是不可想象的，就算南亚次大陆被基本纳入一个政权之中，那也是突厥人和蒙古人的事情，而印度人是被统治者。只有在中国，在西晋灭亡之后不到三个世纪，隋唐帝国就再次统一了国家，并且随着帝国的再次统一，分裂的力量随着时间越来越削弱了，而政治统一越来越巩固，到了帝国晚期的明清两个朝代，像三国南北朝五代十国那样的分裂局面已经是难以想象的事情了。到这里，根本性的差异浮现出来。在进行以上推断的时候，我们实际上采取了一种类似于电力工人检修的办法，先用测电笔测第一个节点没有问题，第二个节点依旧没有问题，第三个节点的时候电流或者电压不正常了，那么我们就可以断言在第二个节点和第三个节点之间电路出现了故障，而现在要做的就是从第三个节点向回寻找到底是哪里出了问题。虽然电路检修和历史学看起来完全不同，但是我从中感受到科学的精神是一致的，而方法则很可能是相通的。既然这种决定性的不同在公元六七世纪之交发生了，那么我们就必须考虑这样一个结论，那就是在再次统一前夕，中国社会显然已经与世界其他地方，特别是与欧洲相比，产生了根本性的差异，那么这种差异究竟在哪里呢？

当推理到达这一步之后，在将近两年的时间里没有取得什么进展。但是在上个星期，一次刷手机短视频的过程中，我忽然间又看到了一个见到无数次的概念：五姓七望。这个词在隋唐时期指北中国最有实力和名望的几个大家族。以前多少次看到这个概念，也并没有什么感觉，但是这一次我突然想到了什么，在中国再次统一的前夜，北方士族有五姓七望，江左六朝中南渡而来的士族以及在南方兴起的本地士族，虽然在侯景之乱中遭受重大打击，但是显然也没有完全消失，比如兰陵萧氏在隋唐时期仍然发挥了相当影响。这个事实意味着，经过了魏晋以来少数民族内迁和大规模入侵的三个世纪的历史进程，虽然我们现在没办法得到具体的比例统计，然而中国的农业地产仍然掌握在汉人特别是汉族地主手里，土地所有权没有发生明显的变化，而这一点本身就是极其奇怪的，因为其与世界其他地方发生的事情明显不符。当仍然处于氏族部落状态的落后民族在文明世界的边缘徘徊，它们的生产力和文化水平会经由学习先进民族（往往就是帝国）而取得迅速提升，在较短的时期内发展到这样一种地步：也就是落后民族迫切地需要更多的土地以建立符合当下情况的生产关系，即一种封建制度下的社会经济关系。

这个问题是显而易见的，当日耳曼人进入西帝国的时候，他们必然最终要把罗马人的土地变为自己的土地，部落领袖和下属的各级酋长变成日后的皇帝，国王以及公爵，侯爵等等。突厥人从东向西最终开始蚕食东帝国的亚洲领地的时候，他们也必然在小亚细亚建立突厥人的封建制度，并在今天形成了土耳其这样一个民族国家。于世界范围内，征服者在获得被征服者的领土后将己方的权贵转换为新土地的

各级封建领主中最典型的事例就是发生在 11 世纪的诺曼征服，一万人的诺曼人征服了有 150 万盎格鲁撒克逊人的英格兰。征服者威廉在全国范围内毫不留情地没收了盎格鲁-撒克逊贵族的土地，将其依照封建关系分封给追随自己从法国而来的诺曼贵族，于是在英格兰范围内土地所有权从整体上看转移到了诺曼征服者手里。关于封建时期土地所有权这个概念，我在第十二章第三十节中进行了说明，有疑问者请自行翻阅。威廉一世在去世之前又在全国进行了土地调查，其类似于日本人所谓的“检地”，制成了《温彻斯特书》（Domesday Book），辅以宣誓会议，最终大大加强了英国的封建制度。诺曼征服好就好在它给出了封建化的一个典型结果，揭示了这样一个事实：剥夺被征服者的土地，将其依照封建政治关系分封给征服者中的大小统治者，是具有封建化需求的蛮族为调整到与其生产力所适应的封建生产关系所不得不做的事。一个巨大的疑问产生了，既然日耳曼人，诺曼人，突厥人，缙人和泰人的行为都遵循这个规律，为什么活跃在中国北方的五胡却没有这么做？这里一定发生了什么没有注意到的事情。

以上疑问随即同中国历史上另一个十分有趣的问题联系起来，那就是所谓的“汉化”问题，为什么来自北方的少数民族两次征服了中国全境，更多次的征服了北中国，其文化和生活方式却最终都几乎完全的中国化了，仅仅留下了少量的痕迹。我们的官方史学同样非常喜欢宣扬这一点，并将其视为中国文化强大的象征。但是一些简单的数学推算表明原因绝不像看起来这么简单，就好比威廉征服英格兰的时候只带了一万有余的诺曼人，当 20 年后对全国的土地清查结束时，英格兰有 150 万人口，那么考虑到他对英格兰的强力清洗，征服之前盎格鲁撒克逊人可能更多。这就意味着，威廉仅仅用不到被征服者 1% 的人力，就完成了在被征服地区强化封建制度的伟业。而在北方少数民族进入中国达到顶峰的时期，也就是公元四世纪和五世纪，即使经过长期残酷战乱，北中国汉族人口仍占了大多数，但是胡汉比例绝对不可能少到 1% 这样的地步，因为即使考虑鲜卑一个民族的人口，那至少也是百万级别的，匈奴人和羌人内迁已久和汉族有相当长的杂居，人口或许也有百万的级别。这样一来，即使是保守的估计北方地区除汉族以外各少数民族人口也得有 500 万到 1000 万，但汉族的人口是绝对不可能到九位数的，这个数量级直至宋朝才能达到。另一个方面讲，十六国南北朝时期的少数民族武装已经相当先进，具装骑兵在北中国变得十分常见，事实上，胡汉之间的技术差距也已经极大地缩小了，我们甚至可以认为在军事上汉人和胡人之间并不存在代差。那么我们可以这样断言，对于北方席卷而来的少数民族征服者而言，要像他们在世界其他地方同行一样将北中国封建化并且用自己的族人完全控制，在实力对比上并非不可能的事情。既然如此，那么北方的少数民族统治者为什么没有做到这一点？

一个关键的思路或许在于卡尔马克思所提出的“劳动创造文化”这一命题（虽然并非他独创，但是马克思将其置于他自己理论的核心），劳动不仅意味着特定的生产生活方式，同样意味着劳动者参与到广泛的社会关系当中。该命题可以用来解释一些有意思的话题，例如，为什么犹太人总是以商人和银行家的刻板印象出现在其他民族的认识中？马克思的观点很好地解决了这个问题，并不是犹太人就显著的比其他民族更聪明，并不是犹太人就生来更擅长于商业和金融，而是由于犹太人自公元前以来就失去了自己的国家在世界各地流浪，他们总在当地社区的人口总数中占小部分，在政治上处于弱势地位。这就导致犹太人一旦实际参与劳动的话，比如成为农民或者手工业者，那他在德国就会成为德国人，在俄国就会成为俄国人，在英国就会成为英国人。恰恰是从事脱产的工作并处于社会结构边缘的位置，处于封闭性的社区当中，从事例如放贷这样的工作，使得一部分犹太人能够保留自己的宗教和文化。所以我们可以说，并不是犹太人天生擅长商业和金融，而是当年选择了这个事业的人才在今天仍被认为是犹太人，而其他直接使用生产资料进行劳动的犹太人都在当地被同化了。这样的例子还有很多，亚美尼亚人在亡国之后也曾经在丝绸之路上流亡过，他们给人的形象同样是善于贸易；而中国人从宋朝以来就断断续续地向东南亚移民，华人在东南亚本地民族那里的形象实际上与犹太人在欧洲的形象几乎一致，都是精明狡猾甚至刻薄。这同样不是因为亚美尼亚人和中国人真的就那么聪明，狡猾且擅长商业，而是只有这样的人才能保留下来原有的民族文化特征，而其他移民渐渐不能与土著相区别罢了。印度的耆那教

（Jainism）则更为有意思，从教义上说它没办法在人民群众中与印度本土诞生的佛教和印度教相竞争，但是其教义做出的限制使得信徒并不会从事农业和屠宰，因而大多数从事商业和贸易。这种脱产的生活反而保证了他们的超然地位，使得其信众在印度庞大的人口虽然显得少，但是却总是能传承下来。

马克思的观点好就在他用一种科学的理论去解释民族问题，而不是归结于神秘主义的不可验证的所谓“民族性”。今天犹太人在世界范围内取得的显赫的社会地位，实际上就是得益于他们在近代之前的中世纪晚期便在商业和金融领域中取得了优势，而接下来两个历史事实的发生使犹太人获得了一飞冲天的机会。其一是近现代化的结果最终使得资本成为最为重要的生产要素，因此获得先机的犹太人自然

近水楼台先得月；其二是欧洲在近现代化的过程中对世界其他地区取得了压倒性的优势，而犹太人也乘风扶摇直上。尽管这个看似传奇的过程最初可能源于基督教徒诸如不允许放贷这样的教义，以至于让犹太人作为不受欢迎者去填补了这个在中世纪后期盘活社会经济中不可或缺的一个“生态位”，但是犹太人的崛起的确是可以社会科学理论来解释的，而不需要诉诸神学。

从相反的方向应用同一个规律，那么我们就得到了另一个事实，占有优势地位的民族可以通过控制社会生产将自己的文化进行扩张。英格兰在这里又是一个典型的例子，尽管诺曼人在最初的征服之后只占英格兰总人口的极小一部分，但是他们确实掌握了英格兰社会中最主要的生产资料，特别是土地。正是由于主导了社会生产，诺曼人得以把自己的文化以无可阻挡的力量强加到盎格鲁撒克逊人的英格兰社会，现代英语所受到法语的影响，就绝不是任何一个曾入关的少数民族的语言对汉语的影响所能比拟的，包括满语。实际上，封建化的蛮族政权没有一个不把自己的文化牢牢地根植在新征服的土地上，一个在12世纪造访德国的旅行家，不可能认为自己还处于古代的罗马帝国，一个在17世纪造访土耳其的旅行家，不可能认为自己还在东罗马帝国，一个在18世纪造访泰国东部的旅行家不可能认为自己还处在高棉帝国。这样的事业正是通过重新分配土地，由征服者牢牢掌握土地的所有权进而直接控制并参与了社会生产，才能够将旧文化进行大面积的扫除，而将自己的统治牢牢巩固起来。正是劳动创造了新的文化，正是对社会生产的主导伸张了这样的新文化。

于是乎毫无疑问，我们现在实际上找到的所谓“汉化”问题的答案，那就是之所以征服中国的少数民族看起来总像一袋盐融化到一个大池塘里一般消失不见，并不是因为汉文化有什么神奇的超自然力量。其根本原因在于他们放弃了封建化，没有直接掌控土地，不直接参与社会生产，当然在工业革命之前主要就是农业生产。但是如果没有封建化，那么少数民族统治者做了些什么呢？回答是：官僚化。